Board 1
West Deals
None Vul

	♠ 9 ♥ A 9 3 ♦ K 5 2 ♣ K J 10 9 6 2	
♠ J 8 6 3 2 ♥ Q 10 8 4 ♦ 9 8 3 ♣ A	N W E S	♠ A Q 10 5 ♥ J 7 6 2 ♦ Q J 10 7 ♣ 5
	♠ K 7 4 ♥ K 5 ♦ A 6 4 ♣ Q 8 7 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	1♣	Pass	3♣
Pass	5♣		
All Pass			

5♣ by North
Lead: ♦Q

Is there any doubt? Although you only have 11 HCP your 6-card suit adds 2 more. And with 13 points you should always open. So you open 1♣.

Partner responds 3♣.

With the ♣ fit your hand is now revalued to 15 points. But it's still a close thing. You may be able to make 5♣ or you may not.

Passing would not be horrible - but when in doubt it is usually better to be bold. You cross your fingers and bid 5♣.

North plays 5♣. East leads the ♦Q.

North plays 5♣. East leads the ♦Q.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 3

The two black Aces aren't going away so if you are to make this contract you must do something about your ♦ loser. And the only likely place to put it is on dummy's ♠K. If East has the ♠A, you can lead up to the ♠K and make a winner out of it.

Suppose you win the ♦Q in dummy and play a ♣. Somebody will win the ♣A and play another ♦. You win this and lead toward the ♠K. No good. East jumps up with his ♠A and sets you with a ♦ winner.

The problem was that when you played a trump you let the timing go to the defense. They could knock out your last ♦ stopper while they still had the ♠A. Try it this way.

Win the ♦ in your hand and immediately play the ♠9. If East doesn't take his ♠A he'll never get it, so assume he goes up. Now he leads ♦J but you win, get to dummy with the ♥K and play the ♠K, discarding the ♦ loser.

Pulling trumps is very important, but sometimes there is something you must do **BEFORE** you play trumps.

In this hand that something is to establish the ♠K so you can discard your ♦ loser.

Board 2
East Deals
None Vul

♠ Q J 5
♥ J 8 7 3
♦ Q 7 4
♣ K Q 10

♠ 10 9 8 7
♥ A
♦ 10 6 5
♣ J 9 5 4 2

♠ K 4 2
♥ 5 2
♦ 9 8 3 2
♣ A 7 6 3

♠ A 6 3
♥ K Q 10 9 6 4
♦ A K J
♣ 8

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		Pass	1♥
Pass	3♥	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♣[2]	Pass	5♥
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 0 or 4 aces

5♥ by South
Lead: ♠10

You have a very good hand. But not good enough to open 2♣, so you open 1♥.

Partner jumps to 3♥.

This is close. Partner has 11 or 12 points and good ♥ support. Your hand revalues to 21 points. You might have a slam. You decide to try for it and bid 4NT. Partner replies 5♣ showing no Aces. So much for the slam. You bid 5♥.

South plays 5♥. West leads the ♠10. You put on dummy's ♠J, East plays the ♠K and you win the ♠A.

South plays 5♥. West leads the ♠T. You put on dummy's ♠J, East plays the ♠K and you win the ♠A.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 1 : Total = 3

You cannot avoid losing either of the two Aces. So therefore you must do something about the ♠ loser. And the only thing you can do with it is to discard it on one of dummy's ♣s.

Be careful. If you lead a trump now a defender will take the Ace and play another ♠, exposing your loser while the ♣A is still out. You must set up the ♣ first. So at trick 2 play your ♣ to dummy's ♣Q. A defender may win this and play a ♠, but you win the ♠Q and play the ♣K, discarding your ♠ loser. Now you switch to trumps.

The way you decide whether to start pulling trumps right away is to use your imagination.

Imagine what the defense will do if you lead a round of trumps. Then imagine what they will do if you play a different suit instead.

Board 3
North Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ Q J 7 4 ♥ A K ♦ 10 8 6 2 ♣ A K Q	
♠ K 10 9 8 ♥ 9 6 3 ♦ Q J 4 ♣ 9 7 2		♠ 5 2 ♥ Q J 10 8 4 ♦ K 9 ♣ J 8 6 3
	♠ A 6 3 ♥ 7 5 2 ♦ A 7 5 3 ♣ 10 5 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♦	Pass	2♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥Q

With 19 points you are too strong to open 1NT so you open 1♦. Partner responds 2♦.

Perhaps you can make 5♦. But 9 tricks are easier than 11 so you bid 3NT. Notice that there was no reason to "show" your ♠ suit. If partner held 4 ♠s he would not have bid 2♦.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥Q.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 3 : Total = 7

You can create one winner in ♦s if they split 3-2, but too late, the defense would have set up their ♥s. So you must get 2 more ♠ tricks.

This is one of the most misplayed positions in bridge. The usual approach is to lead the ♠Q, hoping that East holds the ♠K. But this can't succeed. If East does hold the ♠K he will cover, either this trick or the ♠J, and someone's ♠10 will become a winner. Of course if West has the ♠K then the finesse will fail, along with your chance of 2 more winners.

The correct way to play for 2 more tricks is to hope **WEST** has the ♠K and lead twice toward your ♠ Q J. So win the first trick, play ♠4 to dummy's ♠A. Lead the ♠3 toward your hand, playing the ♠J if West plays low. (Of course if West ever plays the ♠K he gives you two winners immediately.) When the ♠J wins, return to dummy with the ♦A and lead the ♠6 toward your ♠Q.

When West holds the ♠K you can always get 3 ♠ tricks if you play correctly.

Board 4
North Deals
None Vul

♠ 6 4
♥ A 7 3
♦ K Q 5 4
♣ A K 8 2

♠ A 10 2
♥ 10 8 4
♦ J 10 9 3
♣ Q 10 5

♠ K 5
♥ J 9 5 2
♦ A 8 6
♣ 9 7 6 3

♠ Q J 9 8 7 3
♥ K Q 6
♦ 7 2
♣ J 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by South
Lead: ♦J

HE WHO KNOWS, GOES You **KNOW** your side has 26-28 points. You **KNOW** your side has 8 or more ♠s. You **GO** to 4♠.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♦J.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♦J.

Losers: ♠ 2/3 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 0 : Total = 3/4

You are definitely going to lose the ♦A and the ♠ A K. Therefore you must plan to avoid losing a third ♠.

You should lead **UP TO** your honor cards. Cover the ♦J and lose to East's ♦A. Win his return (probably another ♦) in dummy. Lead a small ♠ to your ♠J. West wins with an honor and probably plays the ♦10. Ruff it, lead a ♣ to dummy and lead the last ♠. If East plays the other high honor you play low. If East plays low you guess whether to play the ♠K, or ♠10. Your best play is to assume the two honors were split and play the ♠Q.

Leading twice toward the ♠ Q J gives you a guarantee on this layout because East held a doubleton high honor.

Now

Here West has taken your ♠J with the ♠A. When you again lead a small ♠ from dummy say that East plays the ♠5.

You might think that West is just as likely to have held an original doubleton ♠ A K as doubleton ♠ A 10, and that playing the ♠9 would be as good a play as ♠Q.

This is untrue for a very classy-named reason - **The Principle of Restricted Choice**. You may not even believe it when you read it, but it's mathematically sound. If West were dealt an original ♠ A K, he would have been just as likely to win with the ♠K as with the ♠A. The fact that he actually won the ♠A makes it less likely that he also holds the ♠K.